

BREAK INTO AEROSPACE

Market Intelligence Analyst

Subdomain Interview Preparation Guide

Targeted for the 2025–2026 Recruitment Cycle

What This Document Covers: Airline market intelligence is simultaneously the most commercially consequential and the most methodologically underspecified discipline in commercial aviation strategy. At its broadest, the term encompasses the full range of analytical activities through which airlines understand the demand environment they operate in — traffic and revenue analysis of existing routes, competitive intelligence on rival carriers' capacity and pricing behaviour, demand modelling for potential new routes, consumer sentiment and booking behaviour research, macroeconomic and geopolitical trend monitoring, and the synthesis of all of these inputs into route recommendations that a network planning team can act on. At its most specific, it is the discipline of answering a single repeating question with sufficient rigour to justify capital allocation decisions: given what we know about current and future passenger demand, what routes should we open, maintain, grow, or close, and at what frequency, gauge, and price?

The analytical challenges that define this sector are genuinely complex. The demand signal for a proposed new route does not exist in the way that historical data exists — you cannot observe what passengers would have flown between two cities that have never been connected by a nonstop service, only what they flew when forced to connect through a hub, which systematically undercounts latent point-to-point demand. The competitive landscape changes faster than any model can fully track — a rival carrier can announce a new route, adjust its pricing algorithm, or enter a new alliance partnership in the time between a market study and the executive presentation that relies on it. The macroeconomic variables that drive air travel demand — GDP growth, consumer confidence, corporate travel budgets, visa and border policy — are themselves the product of forecasting processes with their own uncertainty ranges, which compound with the uncertainty in the aviation demand model. And the route recommendation that emerges from this layered analytical process must be presented to a network planning committee with sufficient clarity and confidence to support a multi-year commercial commitment, while honestly conveying the assumptions and their sensitivity.

The employer landscape spans the major network carriers who maintain in-house market intelligence functions (Delta Air Lines Revenue Management and Network Planning, United Airlines Network Strategy, American Airlines Commercial Strategy, British Airways Revenue Management, Lufthansa Group Network Planning, Air France-KLM Market Intelligence, Singapore Airlines Network Planning, Emirates Strategic Planning, Qatar Airways Commercial Development), the low-cost and ultra-low-cost carriers whose leaner organisations concentrate the market intelligence function more narrowly (Ryanair Market Development, EasyJet Network Planning, Southwest Airlines Network Planning, IndiGo Strategy), the aviation data and analytics companies that supply the underlying data infrastructure and sell market intelligence as a service (Cirium — formerly Flight-Global, OAG Aviation Worldwide, Sabre AirVision and Sabre Market Intelligence, Amadeus Network and Schedule Planning, IATA Economics, ForwardKeys, OAG Traffic Analyser, Ailevon Pacific Aviation Consulting), the management consultancies with dedicated aviation practices (McKinsey Center for Future Mobility, Oliver Wyman Aviation, Roland Berger Transportation, ICF Aviation, Bain & Company Transportation), airport commercial development teams who use route development intelligence to attract new airline services (Heathrow Commercial Development, Changi Airport Group Route Development, Dubai Airports Commercial), and the regional and national tourism boards that commission aviation market studies to understand air connectivity needs (VisitBritain, Singapore Tourism Board, various national civil aviation authorities).

The analytical baseline is shared across all of these employers — the economics of yield management, the structure of global distribution system booking data, the methodology of traffic flow analysis — but the specific research questions, the data access, and the career trajectory differ substantially between a market analyst at Delta's network planning team and a consulting associate at Oliver Wyman Aviation.

PART I: WHAT MARKET INTELLIGENCE ACTUALLY LOOKS FOR

By Level

Intern / Graduate

At entry level, airline market intelligence employers are not primarily screening for deep aviation economics expertise — they are screening for strong quantitative and analytical foundations (data analysis, statistical modelling, Excel and SQL proficiency, economic reasoning, and clear written and verbal communication), combined with the specific intellectual quality that the market intelligence function most values: the ability to synthesise ambiguous and incomplete data into a defensible commercial recommendation.

This last quality is particularly important in market intelligence because the data is never complete enough to eliminate uncertainty, and the analyst who waits for certainty will never produce anything useful. The new route analysis that comes back marked “insufficient data” is not an analytical product — it is an analytical failure. The same data, approached by an analyst who understands what the available proxies can and cannot tell you, who knows how to use connecting traffic flows as a lower bound for point-to-point demand, who can triangulate from tourism statistics and bilateral trade data to produce a demand range estimate, and who presents the estimate with explicit assumptions and sensitivity ranges, is an analytical product that a network planning team can act on.

Graduate interviews at major carriers and aviation analytics firms typically involve a combination of quantitative competency (can the candidate perform a market sizing calculation from publicly available data, or interpret an OAG schedule dataset to identify competitive capacity changes?), analytical communication (can the candidate explain what a market analysis shows and what its limitations are, to a non-technical audience?), and aviation market awareness (does the candidate understand the difference between origin-destination demand and leg demand, what MIDT data is and what it measures, and what a load factor means for route economics?). At consulting firms with aviation practices, the screen is heavier on structured problem-solving — the candidate’s ability to decompose a market entry question into its component parts, form a hypothesis, identify the data needed to test it, and communicate a recommendation under time pressure.

Mid-Level (Analyst, Senior Analyst, Associate, ~3–8 years)

At mid-level, market intelligence interviews become project-specific and methodology-focused. The sector’s defining challenge at mid-level is model credibility: not the construction of any individual analytical tool, but the defence of the analytical framework in front of a commercially sceptical audience — the network planning director who wants to know why the demand forecast is 15% higher than the IATA industry consensus, the CFO who wants to understand what assumption is most responsible for the route’s projected profitability, or the alliance partner whose own market model produces a different answer.

The specific question that most reliably reveals mid-level market intelligence depth is about the contested analysis: “your demand model for the proposed new route between Bangalore and Frankfurt shows a year-one load factor of 74%, but the network planning team is sceptical because Lufthansa tried and failed on this route in 2019 — walk me through how you would explain the difference between your forecast and the historical result, what has changed in the market that your model captures and Lufthansa’s 2019 operations did not benefit from, and what the key assumptions are that, if wrong, would bring your 74% forecast below the 70% breakeven.” The candidate who can reason through the demand drivers that have changed (Indian IT sector growth, the post-pandemic recovery of corporate travel, the bilateral air services agreement capacity expansion, the changes in competing itinerary quality via Middle Eastern hubs), what the historical load factor data actually shows about the route’s demand profile, and what the critical assumptions are in the forecast is demonstrating the analytical and commercial depth that senior hiring managers specifically assess.

Senior (Lead Analyst, Manager, Director, Head of Market Intelligence)

At senior level, market intelligence interviews assess the ability to make and defend the architectural and strategic technical decisions that determine whether a programme succeeds. The senior market intelligence professional is the person who decides what data sources the organisation needs and negotiates the contracts to acquire them, who designs the analytical methodology that will be applied consistently across market evaluations, who builds the team of analysts whose work feeds the network planning process, and who represents the function’s output in executive-level commercial decisions.

The distinguishing credential at senior level is having built or significantly transformed a market intelligence capability — having identified a gap in the organisation’s analytical toolkit, designed a solution, secured the resources to implement it, and delivered analytical products that changed commercial decisions that would

otherwise have been made differently. Professionals who have done this, and who can describe the specific analytical gap, the solution they designed, and the commercial decision it influenced, have the function-building experience that is genuinely rare and that growing market intelligence practices specifically seek.

Hands-On Experience and Domain Knowledge Treated as Strong Signals

- **Origin-destination demand data and the MIDT — the primary data source for market intelligence and its limitations.** The Marketing Information Data Tapes (MIDT) — booking data collected from global distribution systems (Sabre, Amadeus, Travelport) and aggregated into origin-destination market statistics — are the foundational data source for airline market intelligence. Understanding what MIDT measures (booked itineraries originating from a given market, captured at the point of booking in the GDS), what it does not measure (direct bookings made through airline websites, which bypass the GDS and are therefore not captured in MIDT — the “GDS bypass” problem that has grown significantly as airlines have invested in direct distribution channels), and how to adjust MIDT data to produce a total market estimate (using GDS capture rate assumptions that vary by carrier and market) is the data literacy that every market intelligence professional must have. The specific limitations of MIDT data — the 6-to-8-week lag between booking and travel that means recent market data is always incomplete, the bias toward GDS-distributed carriers that understates low-cost carrier market share in most markets, and the inability to identify true origin-destination demand versus connecting hub demand — are the analytical caveats that distinguish professionals who have worked with the data from those who have read about it.
- **OAG schedule data and capacity analysis — how to track competitive capacity and identify market trends.** OAG (Official Airline Guide) schedule data is the definitive source for airline schedule information — all published flights, their frequencies, their aircraft gauge, and their seat capacity. Understanding how to use OAG data to analyse competitive capacity in a market (seats per week between two cities, broken down by carrier and service type), identify new route announcements, track aircraft gauge changes that signal demand trend changes, and compute historical capacity trends in a market are the competitive analysis competencies that market intelligence roles require on day one. The distinction between published capacity (scheduled seats) and operated capacity (seats actually flown, net of cancellations and schedule changes) — and the traffic data sources, such as Cirium’s schedule performance database, that track the difference — is a specific analytical literacy that advanced market intelligence work requires.
- **Demand forecasting methodology — the S-curve model, gravity model, and their application and limitations.** Aviation demand forecasting rests on two primary methodological frameworks. The gravity model — which predicts traffic flow between two cities as a function of their population, GDP, and the “distance” between them (adjusted for service quality) — provides a theoretically grounded baseline estimate of potential traffic in an unserved or underserved market. The S-curve model — which relates an airline’s market share to its schedule share in a given market, capturing the disproportionate booking preference that accrues to the carrier with the most frequent service — is used to estimate the load factor and revenue share a new entrant would achieve in a competitive market. Understanding the empirical basis for both models (the gravity model parameters are estimated from existing traffic flows and must be recalibrated for different regional markets; the S-curve relationship changes depending on the level of service quality differentiation between carriers), the assumptions they rest on, and the scenarios in which they produce systematically biased estimates are the forecasting methodology competencies that every mid-level market intelligence analyst must be able to articulate and defend.
- **Airline revenue management and its interaction with market intelligence — how pricing behaviour shapes observable demand.** Revenue management — the discipline through which airlines set and adjust prices to maximise revenue from a given capacity deployment — interacts with market intelligence in ways that can confuse a naive analysis. A market that appears to have low demand based on load factor data may in fact have suppressed demand at current price levels — the airline is filling only 65% of its seats because its pricing algorithm is holding fares at levels that price out the bottom of the demand curve, not because underlying demand is limited. Conversely, a market with high load factors may be supply-constrained rather than demand-driven — the airline is filling 90% of seats because it is not deploying enough capacity to satisfy the available demand, which means the apparent demand signal understates the true market opportunity. Understanding how revenue management decisions shape the

observable data — and how to distinguish a demand-driven high load factor from a supply-constrained one, or a demand-driven low load factor from a price-suppressed one — is the analytical literacy that distinguishes sophisticated market intelligence from naive data reporting.

- **Bilateral air services agreements and regulatory slot constraints — the policy framework that limits where airlines can actually fly.** Air travel between most pairs of countries is governed by bilateral air services agreements (ASAs) — treaties that specify which airlines from each country are permitted to operate services, at what frequencies, between which city pairs, and with what pricing freedom. Understanding how ASAs constrain route opportunities (a market with strong demand may be commercially inaccessible if the bilateral does not permit the capacity required), how Open Skies agreements (the US–EU Open Aviation Area being the most significant) liberalise markets, how slot constraints at congested airports (London Heathrow, Tokyo Haneda, Frankfurt, Amsterdam Schiphol) create additional barriers to new route development beyond the bilateral framework, and how airlines navigate the capacity negotiation process within bilateral frameworks are the regulatory context competencies that market intelligence analysis must incorporate. A new route recommendation that does not account for the bilateral capacity available is analytically incomplete regardless of the quality of the demand forecast.
- **Consumer sentiment and forward-looking demand indicators — the non-traditional data sources that anticipate market trends.** Traditional aviation market data — MIDT booking files, OAG capacity data, published load factors — is inherently backward-looking: it tells you what happened, not what is about to happen. The most valuable market intelligence function is one that anticipates demand shifts before they appear in the historical data, using forward-looking indicators: forward booking curves (how the booking pace for future travel dates compares to the same date in prior years, a leading indicator of demand strength or weakness), Google Trends search volume for flight-related queries (a 4–6 week leading indicator of booking activity in a specific market), ForwardKeys booking data (near-real-time GDS booking activity), visa issuance statistics (a leading indicator of international travel intent), and corporate travel survey data (forward indicators of business travel demand). Understanding which of these indicators has which lead time, which is most reliable for which market segment (leisure versus business, short-haul versus long-haul), and how to weight conflicting signals from different indicators are the analytical competencies that market intelligence functions use to differentiate their insight from what any competitor can derive from the same public data.
- **Airport and tourism authority route development — the external intelligence function that operates from the demand side.** Airlines are not the only organisations that perform market intelligence on air routes — airports and tourism boards actively analyse air connectivity gaps and approach airlines with route development proposals backed by demand analysis and, in many cases, financial incentives (marketing support, fee waivers, guaranteed minimum revenues in the first operating year). Understanding how the route development process works from the airport or tourism board side — what data they present to airlines, what financial incentives are available and what conditions attach to them, and what the airline decision process looks like from the outside — provides a perspective on market intelligence that is valuable regardless of which side of the negotiation the analyst is working from. The ASA Route Development Conference (Routes World, Routes Europe, Routes Americas, Routes Africa, Routes Asia) is the primary industry forum at which airports pitch airlines and airlines signal their network development intentions, and professionals who have attended and understood the commercial dynamics of these events are demonstrating sector engagement that distinguishes them from desk-based analysts.
- **Competitive scenario analysis — modelling the consequences of a rival carrier’s network decision before it happens.** The most commercially valuable market intelligence is not a description of the current competitive landscape but a prediction of how a rival carrier is likely to respond to a network move — and, conversely, what the market intelligence signals suggest about a rival’s likely next move before it is announced. Understanding the competitive analysis methods used to anticipate rival behaviour (analysing the competitor’s aircraft order book and delivery schedule to understand where incremental capacity must be deployed, modelling the competitor’s network economics to identify routes where its costs put it at a disadvantage, reading conference presentations and investor day slides for strategic signals about network priorities) and the frameworks used to model the demand consequence of a competitor’s market entry or exit (the S-curve response to a change in schedule share, the fare-war scenario in which competitive entry drives yields below breakeven for both carriers) are the competitive

intelligence competencies that senior market intelligence roles specifically require.

How Market Intelligence Interviews Differ from Generic Data Analytics and from Airline Operations Roles

- **The recommendation matters more than the analysis.** In most data analytics roles, producing a rigorous analysis is the deliverable. In airline market intelligence, the analysis is only the means to a recommendation — and the recommendation must be specific, actionable, and defensible in front of a commercial decision-maker who will probe it. “The data suggests there may be demand on this route” is not an analytical product. “We recommend launching three weekly flights to Bangalore from Frankfurt in the summer 2026 schedule, at a 32W gauge, targeting a year-one load factor of 72%, reaching breakeven contribution in month eight, with the primary risk being downside performance by 8–10 points if the Lufthansa competitive response to our announcement is more aggressive than the base case assumes” is an analytical product. The ability to form and defend a specific recommendation — not to hedge behind uncertainty — is the commercial skill that market intelligence employers test.
- **The data is always incomplete, and the analyst must say so usefully.** Aviation market data has systematic gaps — GDS bypass, MIDT lag, the absence of ancillary revenue in load factor statistics, the incompleteness of MIDT for low-cost carrier bookings — and the analyst who pretends the data is complete will produce analyses that appear more certain than they are and will eventually be discredited when the forecast misses. The analyst who says “the data is incomplete, so I cannot answer the question” produces nothing useful. The market intelligence professional who says “the MIDT data captures approximately 70% of this market based on our GDS capture rate estimate; the remaining 30% is primarily Southwest bookings, and we have estimated their share from their published load factors and frequency data, introducing an uncertainty range of ± 8 points on the market size estimate” is being honest about the data’s limitations in a way that is commercially useful. This specific analytical honesty — naming the gaps, quantifying their impact, and proceeding with a calibrated estimate — is the intellectual posture that market intelligence employers specifically value and that the interview will probe.
- **The unit of analysis is the market, not the flight.** Operations and revenue management professionals focus on individual flights — the load factor on UA903 from Newark to London Heathrow on a specific date. Market intelligence professionals focus on markets — the total passenger demand between the New York metropolitan area and the London metropolitan area, across all carriers, service types, and date ranges. Thinking in market terms — understanding that a low load factor on one carrier’s service may reflect strong overall market demand being split across multiple competitors, while a high load factor on another carrier may reflect thin market demand concentrated on a single carrier — is the analytical perspective that distinguishes market intelligence from operations analysis, and the interview will specifically probe whether the candidate naturally reasons at the market level.
- **The time horizon extends beyond the booking curve.** Revenue management is focused on the next 90–180 days — the booking horizon within which prices can be set and adjusted to maximise revenue from a given capacity deployment. Market intelligence is focused on the next 2–5 years — the strategic horizon within which route investments must be planned, fleet capacity must be ordered or leased, and alliance relationships must be developed. The ability to reason credibly about demand 3–5 years out — incorporating macroeconomic forecasts, demographic trends, geopolitical scenarios, and competitive evolution — while being appropriately humble about the uncertainty of long-range forecasting is the temporal perspective that market intelligence specifically requires and that operations analysts who have not worked in a strategic function often underestimate.
- **The internal customer is as important as the external data.** Market intelligence exists to inform decisions, and the decisions are made by network planning, commercial strategy, and executive leadership — not by the market intelligence team itself. The analyst who produces brilliant work that no one reads, acts on, or trusts has produced nothing of commercial value. Understanding how to frame analysis for a network planning audience (what they care about, what their objections will be, what format they find most useful), how to manage the relationship between the market intelligence function and the revenue management function (which uses the same data for different purposes and may reach different conclusions), and how to present uncertainty in a way that informs rather than undermines confidence in the recommendation are the stakeholder management skills that market intelligence roles require in

addition to technical analytical competency.

PART II: 20 SPECIFIC PREP TASKS

INTERN / GRADUATE

1. Understand the airline market intelligence ecosystem — the data sources, the analytical function, the internal customers, and the decision process they support 4–5 hours

Skill: The system-level map of the commercial aviation intelligence landscape that frames every analytical role within it

Why the field cares: Market intelligence does not exist in isolation — it exists to serve a network planning process, which serves a fleet planning process, which serves a capital allocation process, which ultimately determines whether the airline grows profitably or misallocates resources. The analyst who understands only the data — and not the decision process it feeds — will produce analyses that are technically competent but commercially irrelevant. Understanding the full chain: which data sources feed the market intelligence function (MIDT, OAG, Cirium, ForwardKeys, internal booking data, third-party economic forecasts), what the market intelligence function produces (market sizing, competitive benchmarking, demand forecasts, route recommendations, scenario analyses), who the internal customers are (network planning, revenue management, commercial strategy, alliance development, executive leadership), and what decisions those customers make using the intelligence function's output — is the commercial context competency that distinguishes analysts who contribute to the business from those who produce technically competent analyses that no one uses.

Done signal: You can describe the airline market intelligence ecosystem's five major components — primary data sources, analytical function, internal customers, external stakeholders (airports, tourism boards, alliance partners), and the competitive intelligence environment — and for each, state what it must provide to the system, what its primary constraints are, and one specific interaction between it and each of the other components. You can explain why a change in GDS capture rate assumptions (say, reducing the assumed capture rate from 75% to 65% due to increased airline direct distribution) would cascade through the market size estimate, the demand forecast, the projected load factor, and the confidence interval on the route recommendation.

2. Understand the primary aviation data products — MIDT, OAG, Cirium, and ForwardKeys — at the level of what each measures, what it does not, and how they complement each other 5–6 hours

Skill: The data foundation that every market intelligence analysis rests on

Why the field cares: Every market intelligence analysis is only as credible as the data it rests on, and the analyst who does not understand the data's construction — its collection methodology, its coverage gaps, its timing characteristics — will produce analyses that contain errors invisible to a non-expert audience but immediately apparent to a practitioner. MIDT measures GDS-booked itineraries and understates direct-booked and low-cost carrier traffic. OAG measures published capacity and does not track cancellations or load factors. Cirium (formerly FlightGlobal) provides operated schedule performance data including completion factors and on-time performance. ForwardKeys provides near-real-time forward booking data with shorter lag than MIDT. Understanding how these four data products complement each other — when to use each, how to reconcile conflicting signals between them, and how to disclose their limitations in an analytical product — is the data literacy that market intelligence employers assess on day one.

Done signal: You have reviewed the product documentation, sample reports, and methodology descriptions published by at least two of the four primary aviation data providers (OAG and Cirium publish substantial free content; MIDT methodology is described in IATA and academic literature; ForwardKeys publishes methodology notes publicly). You can describe for each: what the data source measures, how the data is collected, what the primary coverage gaps are, and one specific analytical scenario in which relying on this data source alone would produce a misleading result.

5–6 hours

You can explain how combining MIDT with OAG capacity data allows an analyst to estimate load factor for a market where the airline does not publish load factor data.

4–5 hours

3. Understand origin-destination demand analysis — the difference between O-D demand and leg demand, how connecting flows are identified, and what itinerary data reveals

Skill: The foundational analytical concept that distinguishes aviation market intelligence from simpler traffic reporting

Why the field cares: The single most important conceptual distinction in airline market intelligence is between origin-destination (O-D) demand — the number of passengers who want to travel between two specific cities, regardless of how many stops their itinerary involves — and leg demand — the number of passengers who physically board a specific flight on a specific segment. These two measures diverge whenever passengers travel via connecting hubs, and the divergence matters enormously for route planning. A market between two cities that have no nonstop service may show very little “demand” in a leg-level analysis, because the passengers are spread across many connecting itineraries through multiple hubs. The same market, analysed at the O-D level, may show substantial latent demand — demand that is currently being served through connecting itineraries but that would prefer nonstop service if it were available. The ability to perform O-D demand analysis — to aggregate connecting flows, apply stimulation factors to account for the demand that nonstop service would generate that connecting service does not, and produce a true market size estimate — is the core technical competency of route analysis.

Done signal: You can explain the difference between origin-destination demand and leg demand, and describe a specific market scenario in which a leg-level analysis would substantially underestimate the true O-D market opportunity. You can describe how MIDT data is structured to allow O-D demand analysis — what the itinerary data contains, how connecting flows are identified, and what the MIDT-to-true-demand adjustment process involves. You can explain what “traffic stimulation” means in the context of a new nonstop service, and describe the factors that determine the stimulation multiplier (the ratio of new O-D demand generated by nonstop service to the existing connecting demand).

2–3 hours

4. Prepare behavioural answers demonstrating analytical rigour, recommendation under uncertainty, and stakeholder communication

Skill: The character signals that market intelligence employers specifically probe

Why the field cares: Market intelligence employers assess whether candidates can form and defend analytical recommendations under uncertainty, whether they communicate complex analytical findings clearly to non-technical audiences, and whether they engage constructively with pushback from commercial decision-makers who disagree with the analysis. The stories that are weakest in market intelligence interviews demonstrate technical execution without commercial impact (“I built a model that forecasted demand”). The strongest demonstrate analytical judgement under commercial pressure (“the network planning team was convinced the route would fail based on the 2019 Lufthansa experience, and I had to demonstrate — using ForwardKeys data showing a 40% increase in search volume from Bangalore to Frankfurt since 2022, and MIDT itinerary data showing a 25% increase in connecting passengers routed via Middle Eastern hubs — that the underlying demand had materially changed since 2019, and that the current competitive alternatives were weaker than they had been”). The candidate who has engaged with publicly available aviation market data — OAG’s publicly available schedule data, IATA Economics publications, airline investor day presentations — and who can discuss them as analytical content is demonstrating the sector engagement that distinguishes committed market intelligence professionals.

Done signal: Four STAR stories covering: a situation where you identified a cross-system implication of a single-system decision; a time you developed a methodology or approach when the standard one did not apply; a situation where you engaged constructively with regulatory ambiguity rather than waiting for clarity; and a time you revised your analytical view based on new information and

2–3 hours

explained the revision to stakeholders. At least two stories involve specific quantitative content — a specific estimate, a specific data source, a specific assumption — not generic analytical process.

3–4 hours

5. Understand the commercial drivers of air travel demand — the relationship between GDP, trade, tourism, and aviation growth

Skill: The macroeconomic foundation that contextualises every market-level demand analysis

Why the field cares: Air travel demand does not exist in isolation — it is driven by the economic and social factors that motivate people and businesses to travel, and understanding those factors is what allows an analyst to distinguish a structural demand opportunity from a cyclical uptick, or a market in secular decline from one experiencing a temporary disruption. The primary drivers of air travel demand: GDP growth (the most robust single predictor of aviation demand growth, with long-run income elasticity of approximately 1.0–1.5 for most markets, meaning air travel tends to grow at 1 to 1.5 times the rate of income growth), bilateral trade flows (a strong leading indicator of business travel demand), tourism flows and visa policy (a leading indicator of leisure demand, particularly on international routes), and population demographics (the size and income distribution of the origin and destination markets). The specific cyclical patterns of aviation demand — the 2001 post-9/11 contraction, the 2008–2009 financial crisis contraction, the COVID-19 demand collapse and recovery — provide the historical context for understanding how demand shocks behave and recover. Analysts who can contextualise a market-level demand observation within the broader macroeconomic and demographic trends that are driving it are demonstrating the analytical depth that distinguishes market intelligence from data reporting.

Done signal: You can explain the relationship between GDP growth and air travel demand growth, and describe how this relationship differs between domestic and international markets, between short-haul and long-haul routes, and between mature and developing markets. You can describe what the income elasticity of air travel demand means and why it implies that air travel grows faster than the economy in developing markets and approximately in line with it in mature markets. You can explain how the post-COVID demand recovery pattern — leisure demand recovering faster than business travel, international recovering slower than domestic — illustrates the different demand drivers at work in different market segments.

6–8 hours

6. Get hands-on with publicly available aviation market data — OAG, IATA Economics publications, airline investor day materials, and Routes conference content

Skill: Specific analytical engagement with the field's actual data landscape

Why the field cares: Unlike many analytical fields where the data is proprietary and inaccessible before employment, aviation market intelligence has a substantial publicly available data infrastructure — OAG publishes weekly schedule data summaries and market analyses, IATA publishes its Economic Performance of the Airline Industry report and monthly Statistics releases, airline investor relations teams publish route network maps and traffic statistics, and the Routes conference series publishes extensive market development case studies. Candidates who have worked with this public data — who have downloaded OAG's free schedule data tools, read IATA's most recent Economic Performance report and can describe the key demand trends it identifies, and have reviewed two or three airline investor day presentations to understand how airlines describe their network strategy — are demonstrating the specific data engagement that generic interest in aviation cannot substitute.

Done signal: You have reviewed OAG's publicly available schedule data for at least one market pair of your choice and can describe the competitive capacity landscape (carriers serving the market, weekly frequencies, aircraft gauge, historical capacity trends). You have read IATA's most recent Economic Performance of the Airline Industry report and can identify three specific demand trends it highlights with the supporting data. You have reviewed the investor day presentation or annual report of at least two airlines and can describe how each characterises its network strategy, what markets it is prioritising for growth, and what the analytical basis for that priority appears to be.

MID-LEVEL (~3–8 years)

All graduate tasks still apply. Analytical stories must come from professional contexts. Methodological knowledge must extend to specific assumptions, their sensitivity, and how the analysis was defended to commercial decision-makers.

7. Build thorough working knowledge of route profitability assessment — CASM, RASM, contribution margin, and what “breakeven load factor” actually means for a route recommendation 5–6 hours

Skill: The financial framework that connects demand forecasts to actionable route decisions

Why the field cares: A demand forecast that shows 70% load factor on a proposed route is analytically meaningless without the cost structure that determines whether 70% load factor is profitable. Cost per Available Seat Mile (CASM) — the airline’s total operating cost divided by the seat capacity it deploys — is the supply-side input that transforms a demand estimate into a profitability assessment. Revenue per Available Seat Mile (RASM) — the total revenue the route is expected to generate per seat deployed — is the demand-side counterpart. The breakeven load factor — the load factor at which RASM equals CASM, leaving zero contribution margin — is the analytical threshold against which every demand forecast must be measured. Understanding how CASM varies by aircraft type (a narrowbody on a short-haul route has a different cost structure from a widebody on a long-haul route), by stage length (CASM decreases as stage length increases due to the fixed cost spread over more miles), and by airline business model (a full-service carrier has a higher CASM than an ultra-low-cost carrier serving the same market) is the cost structure literacy that allows a market intelligence analyst to produce route recommendations that are commercially defensible, not just demand forecasts that describe a market without assessing whether the airline should serve it.

Done signal: You can explain the relationship between CASM, RASM, load factor, and breakeven for a route, and work through a simplified example — given a specified CASM, a specified average fare, and a specified seat count, computing the breakeven load factor. You can explain how stage length affects CASM and why this means that long-haul routes can be profitable at lower load factors than short-haul routes if the yield (revenue per passenger mile) is maintained. You can describe what “contribution margin” means in a route context — the revenue the route contributes above its direct operating costs — and why this is the relevant financial metric for a new route evaluation rather than full cost profitability, which includes overhead allocations that are not incremental to the route decision.

8. Understand competitive response modelling — how to anticipate rival carrier behaviour and incorporate it into a route forecast 5–6 hours

Skill: The analytical competency that distinguishes market intelligence from demand modelling

Why the field cares: A demand forecast that assumes the competitive landscape will remain unchanged after your airline announces a new route is analytically naive — incumbent carriers almost always respond, and the nature and speed of that response materially affects the route’s financial outcome. Competitive response modelling requires: understanding the incumbent’s cost position and capacity constraints (a carrier with spare aircraft and high fixed costs has a stronger incentive to match your capacity with its own than one that is constrained), modelling the yield impact of competitive entry using the S-curve relationship (as the new entrant’s schedule share increases, its load factor rises but the incumbent’s yield falls, and vice versa), estimating the incumbent’s likely pricing response (a deep-pocket incumbent may price below cost to discourage entry; a constrained incumbent may cede market share), and incorporating the possibility of retaliation in the new entrant’s home market. Professionals who have built competitive scenario analyses — who have modelled a three-way market with a new entrant and two incumbents, estimated the yield impact under different competitive response assumptions, and presented the recommendation with explicit scenario labels — are demonstrating the analytical sophistication that senior market intelligence roles require.

Done signal: You can describe the S-curve relationship between schedule share and load factor (or market share) and explain why it implies a first-mover advantage in schedule-driven markets. You can describe how a competitive scenario analysis is structured — what the base case, upside, and downside scenarios assume about competitive response, and what the demand and yield implica-

5–6 hours

tion is in each case. You can describe the specific competitive intelligence inputs that allow you to assess which scenario is most likely — the incumbent's published capacity utilisation, its fleet plan, its financial position, and its stated network priorities from investor communications.

2 hours

9. Prepare a technically specific story about a demand forecast you built that was challenged — what the challenge was, how you responded, and what happened

Skill: The analytical credibility under commercial pressure that distinguishes effective market intelligence professionals

Why the field cares: Every market intelligence analyst who has produced a route recommendation has experienced the situation where the network planning team, the CFO, or the CEO disagrees with the analysis. The response to that challenge is the moment that reveals the analyst's professional character. The analyst who retreats from the recommendation to avoid the conflict produces whatever number the senior stakeholder wants to see, and eventually the function loses credibility because its output reflects stakeholder preferences rather than analytical findings. The analyst who defends the recommendation by restating the analysis without addressing the specific objection demonstrates inflexibility. The analyst who engages with the specific objection — who identifies whether the challenge reflects a data interpretation difference, a methodological disagreement, or a different view on an assumption — and who either revises the estimate on the basis of new information or maintains it with a clearer articulation of why the objection does not change the conclusion, is demonstrating the analytical maturity that the function requires.

Done signal: You have a story about a demand forecast or market analysis you produced that was challenged by a stakeholder — in a professional context. The story describes the specific analysis (the route or market, the key finding, the methodology), the specific nature of the challenge (a data interpretation difference, a methodological objection, a different assumption), how you responded (what you investigated, what additional analysis you performed, what you found), and what the outcome was (whether you revised the estimate, maintained it, or found a middle ground — and what happened to the route decision). The story is specific — it names the market, the data source, the challenged assumption — and demonstrates that you engaged with the challenge substantively rather than defensively.

4–5 hours

10. Understand bilateral air services agreements and their impact on market intelligence — what they permit, what they constrain, and how Open Skies changes the analysis

Skill: The policy and regulatory context that determines which route opportunities are commercially accessible

Why the field cares: A route that shows strong demand potential in the market intelligence analysis is only actionable if the bilateral air services agreement between the two countries permits the airline to serve it at the required frequency and capacity. Understanding the ASA framework — how bilaterals designate carriers, specify capacity entitlements (sometimes in weekly frequencies, sometimes in seats, sometimes in aircraft types), and set pricing freedom — is the regulatory literacy that prevents the market intelligence function from recommending routes that are commercially attractive but legally inaccessible. The evolution of bilateral agreements toward Open Skies liberalisation — the US Open Skies programme (with over 130 countries), the EU External Aviation Policy that creates bloc-level Open Skies agreements, and the ASEAN Open Skies framework — has dramatically expanded the set of commercially accessible route opportunities for carriers from liberalised markets, while carriers from countries without Open Skies agreements continue to operate within capacity constraints that limit their ability to respond to market opportunities. Understanding where the bilateral constraints bind, how to identify ASA capacity headroom, and how the diplomatic process for expanding bilateral capacity works are the regulatory intelligence competencies that market intelligence analyses of international routes must incorporate.

Done signal: You can explain how a bilateral air services agreement specifies the capacity entitlements of each country's designated carriers, and describe what "designated carrier" means in the

4–5 hours

context of a traditional bilateral versus an Open Skies agreement. You can explain what “Fifth Freedom” traffic rights are and why they are commercially significant for hub carriers. You can describe how an analyst would determine whether a specific proposed international route has sufficient bilateral capacity headroom, what data sources are used (ICAO’s Provisions database, IATA’s Bilateral Agreements documentation, the carrier’s regulatory affairs team), and what the process is for seeking additional bilateral capacity if headroom is insufficient.

4–5 hours

11. Understand the route development process from an airport perspective — how airports use market intelligence to attract airlines and what incentive structures they offer

Skill: The demand-side perspective on route development that provides a different view of the same market intelligence problem

Why the field cares: Airlines are not the only organisations doing market intelligence on route opportunities — airports, tourism boards, and regional development agencies actively commission and produce market intelligence to identify air connectivity gaps and to support their pitch to airlines. Understanding how the airport-side route development process works — what data airports present to airlines, how they structure their commercial proposals (marketing support, fee waivers, aeronautical charge discounts, minimum revenue guarantees), and what the airline’s decision process looks like from the outside — provides market intelligence professionals with a perspective on route development that is valuable regardless of which side of the negotiation they are working from. The Routes conference series (Routes World, Routes Europe, Routes Americas, Routes Africa, Routes Asia) is the primary industry forum for this interaction, and understanding the analytical framework that airports use to pitch routes — the “route case” that combines market demand analysis, connectivity gap identification, and commercial incentive packaging — is the full-picture route development intelligence that senior market intelligence professionals require.

Done signal: You can describe the structure of an airport’s route development pitch to an airline — identifying the key components of a route case (market demand analysis, competitive landscape assessment, catchment area analysis, connectivity gap identification, and commercial incentive proposal) and explaining the analytical basis for each component. You can explain what a minimum revenue guarantee is, how it is structured, and what risks it transfers from the airline to the airport or tourism board. You can describe the decision criteria that an airline typically applies to an airport route development proposal, and identify the analytical outputs from a market intelligence function that would most directly address those criteria.

4–5 hours

12. Build working knowledge of alliance and codeshare network intelligence — how interline and codeshare flows affect O-D demand analysis

Skill: The network architecture awareness that is essential for analysing connecting and interline market flows

Why the field cares: A significant proportion of international air travel — particularly on long-haul routes — is carried on itineraries that involve multiple carriers, either through interline agreements (where two separate tickets are issued but coordinated) or codeshare arrangements (where one carrier’s code appears on a flight operated by another). The market intelligence analyst who does not understand how these flows appear in MIDT data — and how to attribute connecting traffic correctly to the underlying O-D market rather than to the hub leg on which it appears — will systematically misestimate market size and competitive positioning. Alliance membership (Star Alliance, oneworld, SkyTeam) creates specific network connectivity patterns that determine which airlines’ connecting itineraries compete for a given O-D market, and understanding the alliance network architecture — who connects where, at what quality of connection, and at what frequency — is essential for competitive connecting itinerary analysis. The emergence of joint ventures (Air France–KLM–Delta–Virgin Atlantic transatlantic JV, Lufthansa–United–Air Canada transatlantic JV, and similar) creates even deeper coordination that affects competitive analysis in specific market corridors.

Done signal: You can explain how a codeshare arrangement appears in MIDT data — whether the

4–5 hours

traffic appears under the operating carrier's code, the marketing carrier's code, or both, and what the implication is for market share analysis. You can describe how to identify connecting itineraries in MIDT data for a given O-D market pair, and explain how to use itinerary data to identify which hub airports and connecting carriers are most actively serving a market. You can describe how alliance membership affects an airline's competitive position in a market that it serves only via connections, and explain what the "virtual nonstop" concept means for alliance partners' ability to compete effectively in markets they do not serve directly.

4–6 hours

13. Prepare for a cross-domain market intelligence problem under interview conditions — a route opportunity assessment or a competitive market entry scenario with cascading analytical implications

Skill: Structured market intelligence reasoning under time pressure

Why the field cares: Mid-level and senior market intelligence interviews consistently include a cross-domain analytical problem — a market assessment that requires integrating demand data, competitive analysis, regulatory constraints, and commercial context simultaneously, under time pressure. "An airport authority has approached your airline with a proposal to launch a new nonstop service between your hub and a secondary city in Southeast Asia. The airport is offering a two-year marketing support package. You have 20 minutes to outline the analytical framework you would use to evaluate the opportunity, the data sources you would consult, the key assumptions you would need to make, and the recommendation criteria you would apply." The candidate who can structure this problem — market size and demand analysis, competitive connecting itinerary assessment, bilateral capacity check, cost structure and breakeven analysis, incentive package evaluation, and the specific conditions under which you would or would not recommend the route — is demonstrating the integrated analytical thinking that market intelligence roles require.

Done signal: You can work through a route opportunity assessment problem in under 20 minutes — integrating market demand analysis, competitive landscape assessment, regulatory constraint identification, cost structure and breakeven reasoning, and commercial risk identification. You have practised this for at least two different scenarios (one short-haul domestic, one long-haul international). You articulate each analytical step explicitly, identify the key assumption at each stage, and arrive at a specific recommendation with stated conditions and caveats.

SENIOR LEVEL (Lead Analyst, Manager, Director, Head of Market Intelligence)

All mid-level tasks still apply. Analytical and methodological knowledge must extend to function design and stakeholder management at an executive level. Commercial credibility must be demonstrable through specific decisions that market intelligence influenced.

4–6 hours

14. Prepare to walk through the most commercially significant route recommendation or market analysis you have personally led — the methodology, the stakeholder challenge, and the outcome

Skill: Senior market intelligence credibility demonstrated through a specific commercially consequential analysis

Why the field cares: Senior market intelligence professionals are specifically valued for having produced analyses that changed commercial decisions — for having identified a market opportunity that the network planning team would otherwise have missed, or having identified a risk in a planned route that prevented a costly mistake. This experience is genuinely difficult to demonstrate without specificity — every analyst claims to have influenced decisions, but few can describe the specific decision, the specific analytical finding that influenced it, and the commercial outcome that resulted. The story must demonstrate not just that an analysis was produced, but that it contained a specific insight that was non-obvious, that the insight was challenged and survived the challenge, and that the route decision — or the decision not to enter the route — reflected the analysis rather than preceding it.

4–6 hours

Done signal: For one route recommendation or market analysis you personally led — where the commercial stakes were significant and the analytical finding was non-obvious — you can describe: the specific market (the route or market pair, the competitive context), the analytical approach you used (the data sources, the methodology, the key assumptions), the specific non-obvious finding (what the analysis showed that was not already known to the network planning team), the stakeholder challenge it faced (who objected, what their objection was, and how you responded), and the commercial outcome (what decision was made, and what happened subsequently). You can describe what you would do differently with the benefit of hindsight.

4–5 hours

15. Prepare a technically grounded position on one active market intelligence frontier — AI-driven demand forecasting, unstructured data integration, or real-time competitive intelligence

Skill: Forward-looking analytical awareness at senior professional depth

Why the field cares: Market intelligence in 2025–2026 has several genuine analytical frontiers where the methodological landscape is changing, the data infrastructure is evolving, and the analytical approaches being developed now will determine competitive advantage in 2030. Machine learning and AI-driven demand forecasting — the application of large-scale pattern recognition to demand forecasting, incorporating non-traditional signals (search query data, credit card transaction data, social media sentiment, weather pattern analysis) alongside traditional MIDT and schedule data — is the primary methodological frontier, with early implementations at major carriers and analytics firms showing meaningful improvements over traditional econometric models in specific market segments. The integration of unstructured data sources — news feeds, government announcements, social media, satellite imagery of aircraft activity at competitor airports — into competitive intelligence monitoring is a rapidly developing analytical capability. Real-time competitive intelligence — tracking competitor pricing, schedule changes, and promotional activity in near-real time using screen-scraping and automated monitoring tools — is becoming a competitive necessity as revenue management algorithms become more sophisticated. Senior professionals who can engage at analytical depth with any of these frontiers are demonstrating the forward-looking perspective that the sector's leadership roles require.

Done signal: You have a prepared 3-minute analytical discussion covering one specific frontier — named specifically: the application of machine learning to aviation demand forecasting and what accuracy improvements have been demonstrated in the literature relative to traditional gravity and econometric models; the integration of alternative data sources (search query data, credit card spend, mobile location data) into market intelligence workflows and what specific analytical questions they can answer that traditional GDS data cannot; or the competitive intelligence monitoring evolution and how automated near-real-time tools are changing the competitive response capability of market intelligence functions. Your position identifies the specific analytical problem, describes the approaches being applied, and states your view on the methodological challenges that remain unresolved.

4–5 hours

16. Prepare to lead a technical discussion on a market intelligence function design decision — insource versus outsource data, build versus buy analytical tools, or specialist versus generalist team structure

Skill: Strategic function management decision-making at the senior level

Why the field cares: Senior market intelligence leaders are called on to make or advise on function design decisions that have multi-year consequences for the analytical capability of the organisation. “Your airline is considering whether to invest \$2 million in licensing a comprehensive aviation market data platform (MIDT, OAG, and ForwardKeys combined) versus maintaining its current approach of licensing MIDT only and supplementing with manual analysis from public sources. Walk through the analytical framework you would use to make this recommendation, the criteria you would apply, and your recommendation given a mid-size carrier with 80 routes and a market intelligence team of four analysts.” This requires reasoning through: what analytical products the current

4–5 hours

approach cannot produce but the comprehensive platform would enable, the productivity improvement for the four-analyst team, the competitive intelligence advantage the platform provides, and whether the \$2 million annual investment is justified by the commercial value of the additional route decisions it would improve. The senior interview tests whether you can structure this reasoning and arrive at a specific recommendation.

Done signal: You have worked through at least two market intelligence function design trade-off problems — one involving a data investment decision and one involving a team structure or analytical capability investment. For each, you state the decision criteria, the two or three options, the key trade-off, and your recommendation with explicit assumptions and sensitivities. You can do this in under 10 minutes per scenario, and you can identify which criteria are most important for the specific airline context (size, network complexity, competitive environment).

4–5 hours

17. Understand how to manage the relationship between market intelligence and network planning — the handoff process, the disagreement management, and the influence without authority

Skill: The stakeholder management competency that determines whether the market intelligence function's output is used

Why the field cares: Market intelligence is a staff function — it produces analysis that informs decisions made by line functions (network planning, revenue management, commercial strategy). The senior market intelligence professional who cannot manage the relationship between the analysis and the decision-maker — who cannot navigate the situation where the network planning team is committed to a route that the market intelligence analysis shows is unlikely to be profitable, or who cannot secure the network planning team's engagement with a market opportunity the analysis has identified — will build a technically excellent function that has no commercial impact. The specific relationship management challenges in market intelligence: the “post-hoc analysis” dynamic (being asked to support a decision that has already been made, rather than to inform a decision that has not yet been made), the “model credibility” challenge (the network planning team has its own analytical view of the market that differs from the market intelligence function's view), and the “bad news” challenge (the market intelligence analysis shows that a route the CEO has announced publicly is likely to underperform). Understanding how to navigate each of these dynamics — and having specific stories about how you have done so — is the influence management competency that senior market intelligence roles require.

Done signal: You can describe the three primary relationship management challenges between a market intelligence function and a network planning function — the post-hoc analysis dynamic, the model credibility challenge, and the bad news challenge — and for each, describe a specific approach you have used to navigate it. You can articulate the difference between a market intelligence function that operates as an order-taker (responding to analysis requests from network planning) and one that operates as a genuine commercial intelligence function (proactively identifying opportunities and risks that network planning has not yet considered). You can describe what the senior market intelligence leader does to build the network planning team's trust in the analytical function's output over time.

4–5 hours

18. Build quantitative estimation fluency for aviation market sizing — total addressable market, realistic achievable demand, and sensitivity analysis — without a full model

Skill: Senior-speed first-principles reasoning about market opportunity size and route economics

Why the field cares: Senior market intelligence professionals are expected to provide order-of-magnitude market assessments quickly — in a leadership meeting, in response to a board question, or in the early stages of a route evaluation before the full analytical process is initiated. “What is the approximate size of the O-D market between Istanbul and Cape Town?” should produce a calibrated estimate within minutes, not a request for two weeks to build a model. These estimation problems are tractable from first principles: applying GDP per capita and population data to estimate the potential travel propensity of each market, applying a gravity model adjustment for distance and connectiv-

4–5 hours

ity, cross-checking against comparable city-pair markets with known traffic data, and adjusting for specific market factors (visa requirements, tourism seasonality, corporate travel drivers). The ability to produce calibrated estimates with stated assumptions and uncertainty ranges — and to identify which assumption is most load-bearing — is the quantitative confidence that executive-facing market intelligence roles require.

Done signal: You have worked through five aviation market sizing estimation problems covering at least two of: estimating the annual O-D demand between two unconnected city pairs using gravity model logic and publicly available population and GDP data; estimating the market share a new entrant would achieve in a competitive market given a specified frequency relative to the incumbent; estimating the revenue impact of a 5-point load factor improvement on a specified route; estimating the demand stimulation from a new nonstop service replacing connecting-only access; and estimating the breakeven load factor for a specified route given publicly available cost benchmarks. You state your assumptions explicitly, identify the most uncertain assumption, and give your estimate with a stated uncertainty range.

ALL LEVELS

1–2 hours

19. Prepare a specific answer to “Why market intelligence — and why this specific role and employer?” that reflects genuine analytical and commercial engagement

Skill: Analytically specific motivation that distinguishes market-intelligence-committed candidates from those who find aviation interesting

Why the field cares: Market intelligence employers receive applications from candidates who are attracted by aviation and by data analytics — two formats with high native appeal. What they are looking for is professionals who understand the specific analytical challenges that market intelligence faces and who have a specific professional contribution to make to addressing them. The expected answer engages with one of: the demand forecasting challenge for a specific underserved market that the employer is known to be considering, and how the candidate’s background in a specific modelling approach applies; the competitive intelligence gap the employer faces in a specific region and what the candidate’s experience with alternative data sources enables; or the GDS bypass problem and what the candidate’s experience with direct booking data or loyalty programme analysis contributes. The answer must name one specific analytical challenge, explain what makes it hard, and connect the candidate’s specific background to contributing to its resolution — not just to a general interest in aviation analytics.

Done signal: You have a 90-second answer that names the specific market intelligence analytical challenge most relevant to your background, explains what makes it hard (the specific data gap, methodological limitation, or stakeholder management complexity), and connects your professional or academic background to contributing to its resolution. The answer demonstrates that you have researched the specific employer’s current analytical capabilities, route network, and competitive context, and can describe one specific analytical challenge — a data gap, a competitive intelligence need, or a methodology limitation — that your background is positioned to address. The answer cannot be given unchanged to a candidate applying to any other market intelligence employer.

1–2 hours

20. Map your analytical background to a specific employer type, role level, and commercial domain — and understand the difference in analytical environment between an airline intelligence function, a data analytics vendor, and a management consultancy

Skill: Precise self-positioning in a sector where employer type determines the analytical questions, data access, and career trajectory

Why the field cares: The market intelligence sector in 2025 spans employers with fundamentally different analytical environments, and the work — and the candidate characteristics required — differs dramatically between them. An in-house market intelligence analyst at a major carrier (Delta, Lufthansa, Singapore Airlines) has access to internal booking data, revenue management system out-

puts, loyalty programme behaviour data, and direct access to the network planning team — but is focused on a single airline’s network decisions and operates within a corporate hierarchy that limits the speed of analytical iteration. A market analyst at Cirium or OAG has access to the broadest possible industry data set and serves multiple airline clients simultaneously — but does not have access to internal airline data and must produce intelligence that is general enough to be relevant across different carriers’ strategic situations. A consultant at Oliver Wyman or ICF has the most varied project work and the most direct exposure to executive-level decision-making — but is always on the outside of the airline’s data environment and must produce recommendations under time pressure with limited data access. A candidate who has not understood these structural differences — and who cannot articulate why their background fits one environment better than the others — is not ready for the interview.

1–2 hours

Done signal: You can state in under 60 seconds: the market intelligence employer type you are targeting (in-house airline function, data analytics vendor, or management consultancy), its specific analytical environment (data access, client base, decision-making proximity, analytical iteration speed), the specific role you are targeting and why your background matches the environment, the analytical tools and data sources you work in fluently, and one specific analytical challenge the employer is currently facing — derived from publicly available information (published research, conference presentations, OAG or Cirium market commentary, airline investor presentations) — that your background is positioned to contribute to.

SUMMARY REFERENCE TABLE

#	Task Description	Target Level	Effort
1	Market intelligence ecosystem — data sources, analytical function, internal customers, decision process	All	4–5 h
2	Primary aviation data products — MIDT, OAG, Cirium, ForwardKeys: what each measures and does not	All	5–6 h
3	Origin-destination demand analysis — O-D vs leg demand, connecting flows, traffic stimulation	All	4–5 h
4	STAR stories — analytical recommendation under uncertainty, data challenge, stakeholder communication	All	2–3 h
5	Commercial drivers of air travel demand — GDP, trade, tourism, income elasticity, market cycles	All	3–4 h
6	Publicly available aviation market data — OAG, IATA Economics, airline investor materials, Routes	All	6–8 h
7	Route profitability — CASM, RASM, breakeven load factor, contribution margin	Mid+	5–6 h
8	Competitive response modelling — S-curve, yield impact, scenario analysis, competitive intelligence inputs	Mid+	5–6 h
9	Challenged demand forecast story — methodology, stakeholder objection, response, outcome	Mid+	2 h
10	Bilateral air services agreements — capacity constraints, Open Skies, Fifth Freedom, headroom analysis	Mid+	4–5 h
11	Airport route development — route case structure, incentive packages, airline decision criteria	Mid+	4–5 h
12	Alliance and codeshare network intelligence — interline flows, MIDT attribution, joint ventures	Mid+	4–5 h
13	Cross-domain route opportunity problem — demand, competitive, regulatory, commercial integration	Mid+	4–6 h
14	Commercially significant analysis story — non-obvious insight, stakeholder challenge, commercial outcome	Senior	4–6 h
15	One active MI frontier — AI demand forecasting, alternative data integration, real-time competitive intelligence	Senior	4–5 h
16	Market intelligence function design decision — data investment, build vs buy, team structure	Senior	4–5 h
17	Market intelligence–network planning relationship — handoff, disagreement management, influence authority	Senior	4–5 h
18	Quantitative market estimation — market sizing, realistic demand, stimulation, breakeven, sensitivity	Senior	4–5 h
19	“Why market intelligence — why this employer and role?” — technically and commercially specific	All	1–2 h
20	Employer type positioning — airline function vs data vendor vs consultancy, analytical environment fit	All	1–2 h

THE STRUCTURAL REALITY THAT MAKES MARKET INTELLIGENCE DIFFERENT

Airline market intelligence is the only aviation analytics discipline in which the product is a prediction about something that has not yet happened — and in which the quality of that prediction cannot be evaluated until the commercial commitment it supported has already been made and its consequences are beginning to accumulate. The revenue management analyst who misforecast yesterday's load factor can see the error in today's data and correct the model. The market intelligence analyst who misforecast the demand on a route that launched six months ago will not see the error for another 12 months of operations, by which time the aircraft is committed, the slots are allocated, the codeshares are operational, and the correction cost is substantial.

This delayed feedback loop — in which the market intelligence function makes predictions whose accuracy is not knowable for years after the prediction is made — is the structural feature that most distinguishes market intelligence from every other aviation analytics discipline and that creates the most important professional challenge for the people who work in it. In revenue management, the model is recalibrated daily against observed bookings. In market intelligence, the model is recalibrated perhaps twice a year against traffic data that is itself 6–8 weeks old, covering routes that were recommended 18 months earlier against market conditions that were different at the time of the recommendation.

The professionals who succeed in this environment are those who can maintain analytical rigour across this extended feedback loop — who document their assumptions with enough specificity to allow a retrospective assessment of which assumptions held and which did not, who build the uncertainty ranges into their forecasts with enough honesty to allow subsequent calibration of the model, and who engage with forecast misses as learning events rather than defending the original recommendation as correct in principle even when it was wrong in practice. They are also those who are genuinely curious about why markets behave the way they do — who want to understand why the Bangalore–Frankfurt route has recovered faster than the model predicted, what that implies about the income elasticity assumption for the South Indian technology sector, and how that revised assumption should be applied to the next Southeast Asian market evaluation in the queue.

This curiosity — about the market, the traveller, the competitor, and the macroeconomic forces that drive demand — is the specific intellectual character that every serious market intelligence employer is trying to find in the candidates they hire, and it is what this document has been structured to help you demonstrate.

BREAK INTO AEROSPACE
